



MEN OF HONOUR: The IMA has 1,650 recruits each year



INDIAN MILITARY ACADEMY, DEHRADUN

HIGH AND MIGHTY

Seventy-four years ago, the 20-year-old son of a Parsi doctor from Punjab was among the first batch of 40 cadets who passed through the spanking new portals of Chetwode Hall at the Indian Military Academy (IMA), Dehradun. His name? Field Marshal S.H.F.J. Manekshaw. The IMA could well have flown mission accomplished banners. The cadets are aged between 15 and 35 years and are National Defence Academy graduates, college graduates and Army Cadet College (ACC) graduates. There are over 120 cadets from 22 nations including SAARC neighbours and Central Asian 'stans'. Guiding them through the year-long course is the IMA's Chetwode credo, laid down in the eponymous hall: "The safety, honour and welfare of your country come first always and every time. The honour, welfare and comfort of the men you command come next. Your own ease, comfort and safety come last always and every time." Adds Lt-General P. K. Rampal, IMA commandant, "But first, you have to prove you are a gentleman and then an officer." The challenges before the IMA have multiplied over the years. With six-figure salaries and material comforts luring the youth, serving the country in tough border outposts has perhaps taken a backseat. Times when the Chetwode credo will be put to the ultimate test.

by Sandeep Unnithan

"First, you have to prove you are a gentleman and then an officer."

LT-GENERAL P.K. RAMPAL, IMA COMMANDANT ON THE ACADEMY'S MOTTO



PARLIAMENT, DELHI

FULL HOUSE

High on pragmatism, in the first session of Parliament in 1952, the then prime minister Jawaharlal Nehru declared, "However theoretically good, the parliamentary democracy has to answer the questions put to it by the age. If it answers the questions, it is well established." Decades later, it has become a hotspot where various questions about the rightness of the country's democracy overlap. Now a witness to the era of cash for questions and money for votes, in its early years, Parliament engaged some of the best minds in public life. Leaders like Ram Manohar Lohia, Lal Bahadur Shastri, Acharya Kripalani and Indrajit Gupta found a place in the nation's mindscape with their wit and wisdom.

Repartee had been the forte of these members. For instance, when Lohia tried to persuade the House to accept an asylum request from Joseph Stalin's daughter, Svetlana, citing her marriage with an Indian, a woman member, Tarkeshwari Sinha, wondered how the bachelor Lohia could speak of conjugal sentiments. Lohia left the House in splits when he replied: "Tarkeshwari, when did you give me any chance?"

Consensus has been an issue in Parliament. Nehru once rejected an amendment by C.R. Rajagopalachari saying: "You see Rajaji, the majority is with me." Rajaji retorted: "The majority is with you but the logic is with me." Nehru joined the House in laughter and accepted

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